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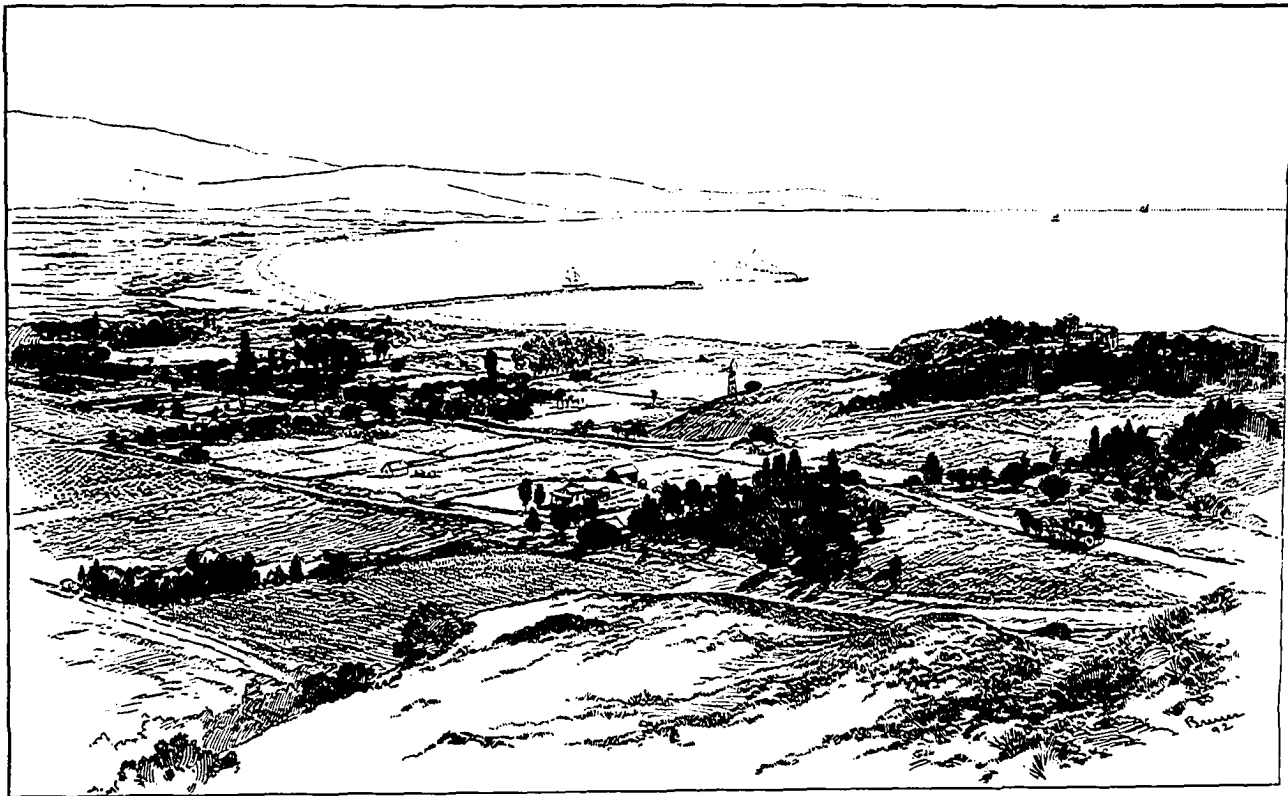
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EDITED BY
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Santa Barbara Bay from the Coach Top.

A FOUR-IN-HAND IN SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA.

BY CHARLES FREDERICK HOLDER



LOS ANGELES, the Queen City of the South, is the metropolis of Southern California, which, speaking generally, may be said to include that tract of country from Santa Barbara County to the Mexican line, though a broader division would include a much larger area. Los Angeles was the starting point, the center of radiation for many of our coaching and riding trips to Santa Barbara and beyond, and through Southern California to the adobes of Tia Juana. To see Southern California effectively the trip should be made by coach, carriage or on horseback. The finest of roads extend all over the country, inviting one to the old ranches, cañons, ruins and Missions that cannot be seen from car windows.

It was a mere conceit, perhaps, but remembering that in the olden time pilgrims and travelers in this fair country found a Mission at the end of nearly every day's journey from San Francisco to San Diego and beyond, we determined to emulate the ancient custom and go over the old roads; not on horseback, as did the old Californian, but in a four-in-hand, making as nearly as possible a Mission every night, seeking the hospitality of its secularized walls in reverential fashion, as did the traveler of the last century, yet receiving it for obvious reasons perchance at the neighboring ruin.

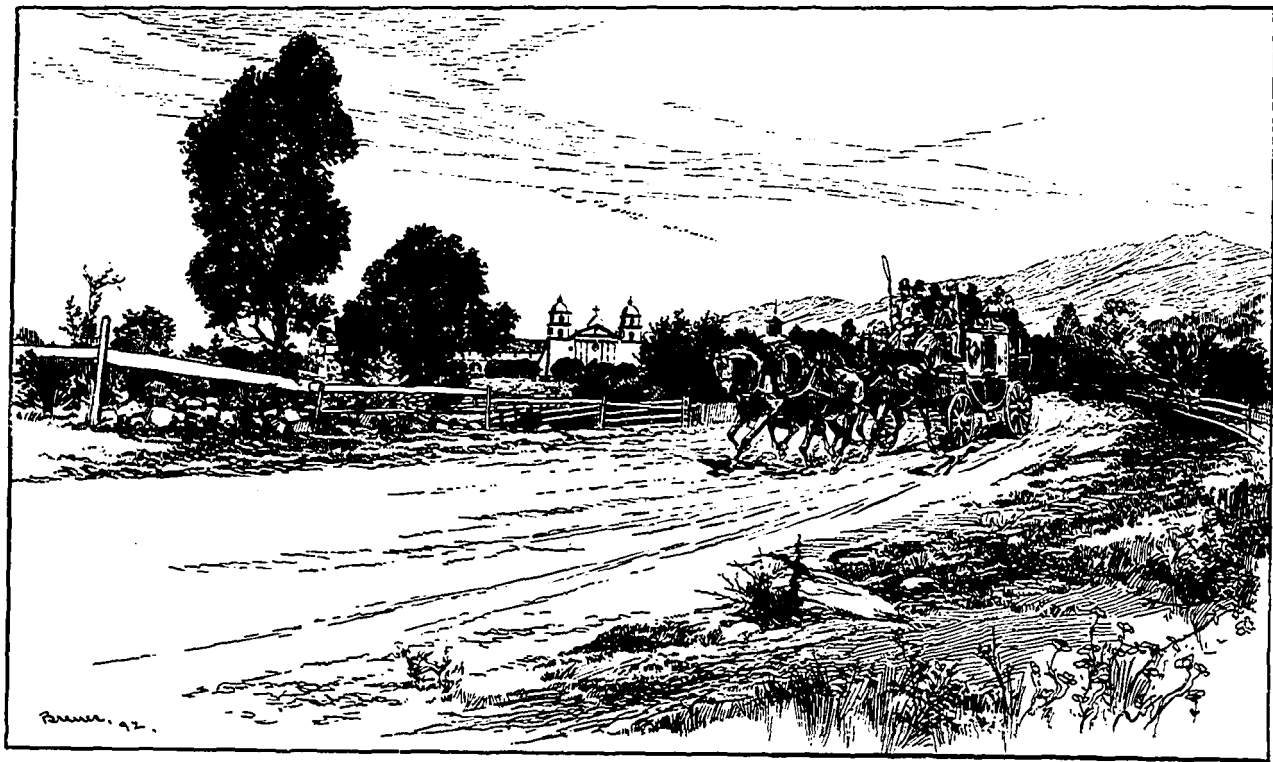
The plan had not only an essence of romance and novelty to commend it but was within the possibilities, the ecclesiastical chain being as follows, beginning at Santa Barbara :

Santa Barbara Mission, founded in 1786, by coach to the Mission of San Buenaventura (1782), thirty miles. From Ventura to Mission of San Fernando Ryz de Espana (1797), sixty-four miles. From San Fernando to the Mission of San Gabriel Archangel (1771), via Los Angeles, thirty-five miles. From San Gabriel to San Juan Capistrano (1776), thirty miles. From San Juan to the trio of Missions of Pala, Rincon, and Panba, about sixty miles. Pala to San Luis Rey de Francia (1798) thirty miles. San Luis Rey to the Mission of San Diego de Acala (1769), fifty miles, these figures being approximate and in the main correct. Not only could these Missions be reached in a single day's journey, but good hotels, often the best, were available. This, with the guarantee of perfect roads, good weather, and choice scenery made the trip one of more than pleasant anticipation.

The four-in-hand was not running on time; there were no relays to be met; hence the attempt to make a new Mission every night was not directly adhered to, though the ecclesiastical route was followed literally as outlined, with many an interesting side-trip to cañon, seashore and mountain range.

Under such inspiration a jolly party bowled toward the Santa Barbara Mission one morning, and reined up under its ancient walls. The "outfit" was a modernized California coach, the plethoric boot packed with hampers of good things; rifles for the black-tailed deer and shotguns for the valley quail, while four or five grey and stag hounds following were suggestive of coursing, with the hare and coyote as objectives.

According to a calendar, which the young lady on the box seat carried,



Down by the Mission of Santa Barbara.

it was that thoroughly uncomfortable period midway the Christmas holidays and the first of March, when, in the East, thaws and violent freezes follow each other like avenging Nemeses; yet here nature seemed conspiring to impugn the testimony of the records. It was winter as the seasons go, but to all intents and purposes midsummer in Southern California. The breeze was coming in from the Pacific, sweeping up the mesa of the old town, bowling over acres of golden poppies, robbing the fields of wild forget-me-not of their odor and carrying it over the Mission wall, to mingle with the incense of the church. The driver called it a winter day; yet as he flecked his leaders and the horn gave an answering note to the meadow lark on the Mission wall, there was not one in the party who really believed that the Ides of March were near at hand.

From the highlands about the Mission the first view of Santa Barbara is obtained. The Pacific is before us, stretching away to illimitable distance, the crescent-shaped beach facing the south, from which reaches back the intervening town with its broad streets lined with palm, pepper, magnolia and a wealth of semi-tropical plants and trees. To the north extends the Santa Ynez Valley, the blue ocean on one side, the mountains to the other, while to the south and east deep groves of orange, lemon and lime tell of El Montecito and Carpinteria.

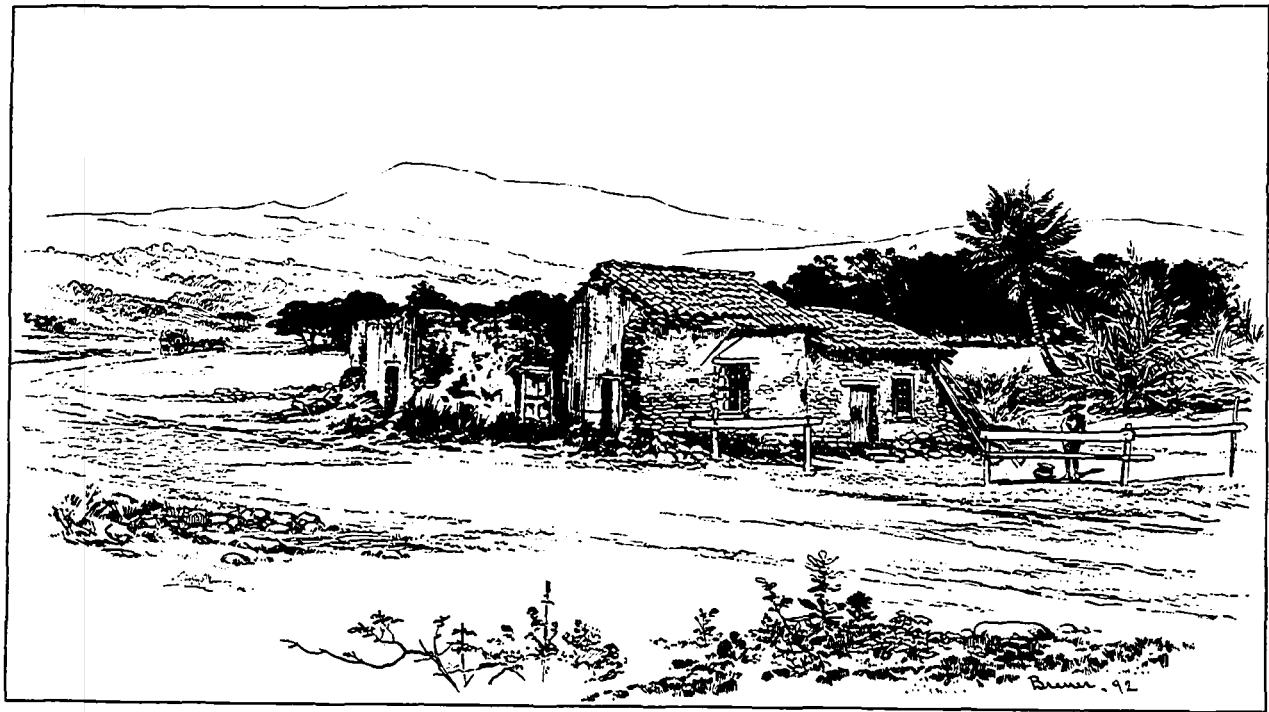
It was at the Mission that the complete supremacy of man was demonstrated, as, after interviewing the courteous Fathers, the gentlemen of the party were invited into the Mission garden, while the ladies rested in the outer hall, consumed with curiosity. No woman had ever entered the garden, so it was said; and the old gardener, gowned and cowed, laughingly told of the pretexts adopted by fair visitors, who evidently believed that the grim walls concealed some deep mystery.

The Mission of Santa Barbara is the only one that has never been out of

Franciscan control, and is one of the finest in the State, standing as it did a century ago when its bells rang the Angelus, their echoes calling the faithful up the deep cañons of the Santa Ynez.

The father told us of the ancient splendors of the church, of its inception by Junipero Serra, its erection in 1786 by Father Antonio Paterna, and detailed its completion in 1794. In 1810-12, he said, it was nearly destroyed by earthquakes, but was ultimately rebuilt. We entered the old dormitories, the workshops once filled with native artisans; stood on the red-tiled roof, and looked down upon the broad arched corridors where the Fathers walk and read; strolled among the ancient graves of the founders, and tarried in the chapel with its quaint decorations while the Father whispered the history of the treasures upon the walls. He told us of the struggles of the Fathers, the act of the Mexican Governor in 1827 in freeing the Indians, resulting in the destruction of the revenues of the Mission; of the desecration that accompanied the demand for secularization, and various efforts at confiscation. In 1833 the Government succeeded, and the Missions were converted into secular curacies. Later the Missions fell into the hands of commissioners, and in 1834 the public literally seized the Mission lands. We listened to the story of the successive phases of the struggle, of the times under Don Juan Alvarado, who, it was claimed, plundered the Missions, of the attempt in 1840 to restore the Missions to power, and of the act of Pope Gregory XVI, in the the same year, making California a bishopric, and many other moves, resulting to-day in the Missions being, instead of centers of ecclesiastical power, simple parish churches.

The Mission as a whole is a delight to the artistic eye. The cell-like rooms, the ancient and worn stone pavements, the crude doors with huge iron trappings, the high windows, enormous walls, the odor of ancient sanctity, all



Down by Spanish Town.

tend to complete a historical picture of the greatest interest. Without, the commanding front with its two towers of stone and adobe pierced with arched doors, the lofty façade with its finely cut columns, the time-worn statues of the saints above, make the pile at once striking and impressive. No little architectural and artistic skill was shown by the builders. Especially does the stone fountain in front, with its round basin and quaint carvings, attract the eye. Near here was an adobe bath-house, in the façade of which a lion's head was carved, from which once poured the clear water of the Santa Ynez. In fact, it is evident that the builders of the Mission were men of artistic feeling; and the old building reflects credit upon their memory.

But we have tarried too long. A number of dark-eyed penitents are waiting for the Father by the confessional, and after handing an ancient nail or spike of the old Mission as a memento to one lady, a photograph of the church and some flowers from the garden to others, the Father disappears to banish the past in the sins of the present generation.

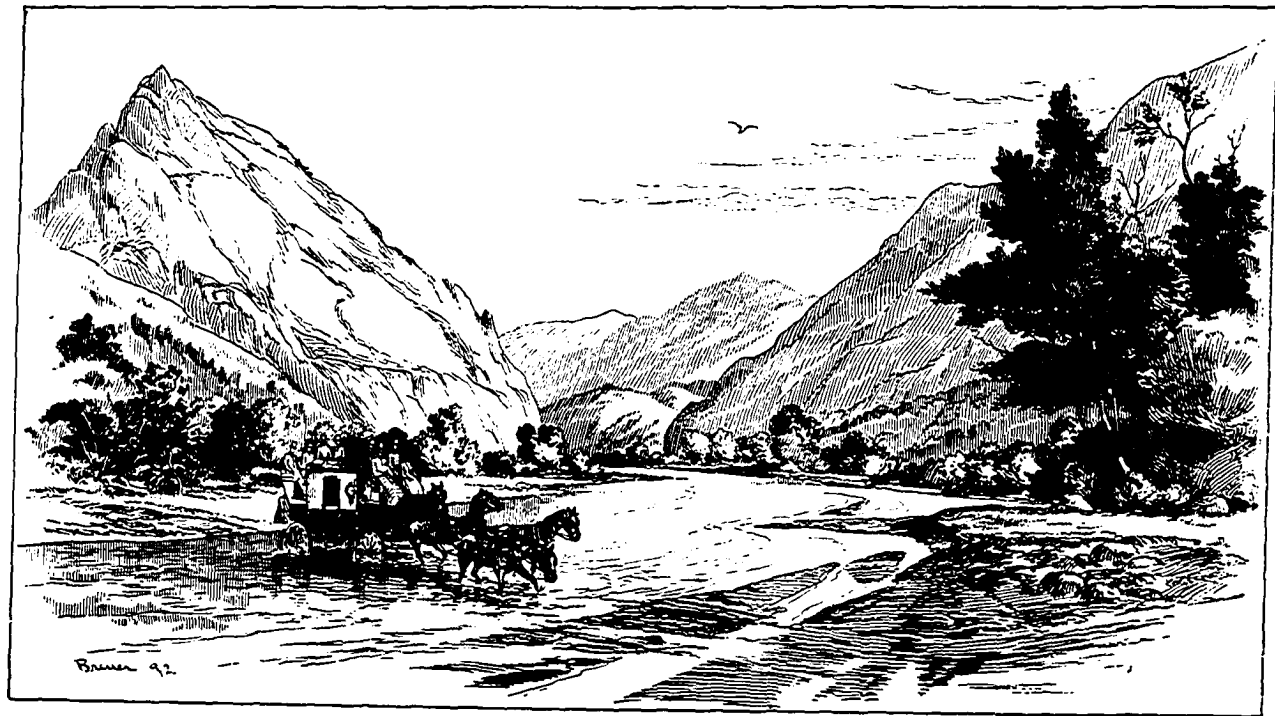
Santa Barbara reminds one of some of the Mediterranean resorts, and has been compared to Nice; but the comparison is hardly just. The American resort has the advantage in climate, is always delightful, winter or summer, but has none of the artificial decorations of European places. Its winter mean is 54.29; that of Nice 47.88; its summer mean 67.71; that of Nice 72; its difference between winter and summer 13 to 24 of Nice. Again, the Santa Barbaran, or Barbarian of the saints, as the young lady on the box-seat calls our host, tells us that the hot, burning winds of Southern Europe are never known here,—that this is the only paradise, the real land of *dolce far niente*, the home of the gods.

The quiet old town with its fine hotels, long asphalt-paved streets, its miles of gardens, shops for the sale of curiosities, its Chinatown, where the

odor of opium and firecrackers mingles with the perfume of flowers, its long wharf, yachts and vessels, all offer inducements to tarry. Spanish-town still remains inviolate, and we stop at the old De la Guerra mansion, where Richard H. Dana witnessed the marriage festival in 1836. The family is still in possession, and the house, with its open court, adobe walls and tiled roof, still resembles the description in "Two Years Before the Mast." We buy a *reboso*, an Indian basket, from an old Mexican woman, some of the stamped-leather articles for which the place is famous, half a dozen fiery tamales from another old woman, for luck, the driver puts it, and are away up the fine, hard road to La Patera, where the Indians buried their stone mortars and household gods in the long ago.

Near here we drive through the fine ranches of Hollister, Cooper and Stowe, the former known as "Glen Annie." "Ellwood," the Cooper homestead, is famous for its olive orchard,—the largest in Southern California, also in America, with works the perfection of neatness, over which the courteous host takes us. The home is embowered with flowers from every clime,—a garden the year round. From here we pass for several miles up the picturesque little cañon by the side of a stream and beneath trees that were young in the days of the Franciscan padres, and finally at the head of the ravine halt for a consideration of the well-filled hampers which the coach is made to disgorge; for this is a feature of coaching in Southern California,—the mid-day meal is carried, and a picnic is enjoyed in some nook or corner that may meet the eye.

From this region endless trips can be made to glens and eyries which, in their beauty, compare favorably with those of European resorts: the Gaviota Pass, the Valley of the Santa Ynez, the mountains rising to the east, while to the west the ocean is seen, here and there,—a reminder of the extremes that Santa Barbara



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Fording the Stream.

affords. Here the lover of the picturesque may spend weeks without exhausting its beauty. But we are off again, rolling down to the beach with its long line of shining sands, calling to mind our own New England shore. But here, the Santa Barbaran tells us, the water on this February day has a temperature of 61 degrees, about that of Newport in June. Tourists are enjoying the surf; the beach is gay with riders, while the castellated rocks on the north are dotted with strollers from the hotels. Over beyond the blue stretch of water that formed the Santa Barbara Channel rose the Channel Islands, the smallest—San Nicolas—having a peculiar interest. In 1836, we are told, the last Indians were taken away; but as they were leaving a squaw ran back to get her child, and for some reason was left and abandoned. In 1856, twenty years later, George Nidever of Santa Barbara landed there on an otter hunt. To his surprise he found huts of whalebone, and near one an old woman, dressed in a garb of skins and feathers. She presented a weird appearance; her language was unintelligible. Nidever took her to Santa Barbara, where every attempt was made to find some one who could talk to her, but without success. What became of her child no one knew. The "lost woman" died three months after her rescue, and was buried by the Mission Fathers, — unknown,—a mystery of a lost people.

We could have reached the famous Ojai Valley, thirty-seven miles southeast from Santa Barbara, through the Casitas Pass, but preferred to go by the Mission of San Buenaventura, thirty miles away. This took us through the delightful suburbs of El Montecito, with its hot sulphur springs far up the cañon, thirteen hundred feet above the sea, where the Indians resorted years ago, by nooks and corners of the Santa Ynez, the San Marcos Pass and the Painted Cave and Rocks.

The stage road winds along the edge of the shore, now desecrated by the

rails of the Southern Pacific, gleaming sandy crescents succeeding one another in endless variety. Through the orange groves of Montecito we enter Carpinteria and its slopes. Here a peculiar patch of black ground being plowed by a Mexican catches the eye of a scientific coacher, who pronounces it the site of an ancient Indian village. The Mexican stops work as the coach slows up, leans upon his plow, and while rolling a cigarette sententiously answers the questions thrown at him singly and in pairs. After much solicitation he finally enters the adobe near at hand and returns with some of the results of his plowing,—ancient relics turned up in former barley seasons: a stone mortar, some abalone shells, the holes stopped with asphaltum, the dishes of the Indians, bits of soapstone with perforations, arrowheads of flint, and, horror of horrors! a flute that some ancient disciple of the muse has manufactured from the arm-bone of possibly a kinsman. It is rudely made, and ornamented with bits of pearl from the abalone. Beads of shell and a flint knife complete the treasures of this collection.

"Who were these people?" asks some one on the top of the coach.

"No sabe, señor," puffs the Mexican.

He might have said that his house was resting on a veritable *kitchen-midden*, a townsite, graveyard, and what not of the early Californians Juan Rodriguez Cabrillo met when he sailed up the Santa Barbara Channel nearly three hundred and fifty years ago. He could have said that the adventurer found this land the site of many villages, where lived thousands of happy natives. He might have told us that his ancestors were of the party, and that they buried the great captain, Cabrillo, on San Miguel over yonder, where he still sleeps. But he said nothing, and looked in stolid amazement at the volubility and learning of the American whip of the strange vehicle.



Stopped by Castle Rock.

Our road follows the beach through Carpinteria, past sand-dunes where rich grasses grow, where the faint track of sea-birds is seen and the roar of the surf breaks gently on the ear. Beyond is the ocean, smooth as glass, with beds of kelp floating lightly,—the resting place of the gull and otter; over beyond the sail of a Chinese junk, the smoke of an American steamer. On we pass, the ocean to the right, the green slopes of the Santa Ynez on the other side, through little cañons that reach down to the shore, playing a veritable game of hide-and-seek with the gleaming ocean. Now the adobe of some Mexican ranges into view, with its barren, well-worn dooryard; its ramada and garlands of chilies, red and glaring, its hairless dogs, and dark-eyed children who have never seen a red and yellow coach and stare hard and long, silent at the melody of the horn.

Down we plunge into the little arroyo, splashing across the clear brook that, with its sparkling sands and dashing trout, comes gurgling down under the arches of elder and willow; up the bank with a rush, winding through a grove of live-oaks

where the tap tap of the woodpecker echoes and the gray squirrel flashes his fox-like tail; out into the fields again, the road lined with yellow violets, with crazy-quilts of color,—blue-bells, cream cups, daisies, poppies, bluettes and other wild-flowers galore, reaching far up to the manzanita and wild myrtle of the upper slopes. From the hillside comes the melody of the valley quail, then the roar of its wings. The nest of the wood-rat hangs on a limb. The air is filled with insect life dancing lightly in the sunbeams.

And so on we go, over the same road that Father Junipero Serra and Governor Felipe de Neve with their guard of sixty soldiers passed when marching to found the Presidio of Santa Barbara one hundred and nine years ago, and with a final burst we ride bravely into the old town of Ventura, cross the shallow river that creeps lazily out from the grove of alders and willows, round the big hill that divides the town, and passing the shadows of the old Mission of San Buenaventura seek the more material comforts of the inn of the roses.

